



crucial juncture in his life. He had been seen as a promising shooter but hadn't quite broken into the world's elite. At 25, he was still striving for that one defining medal. He had finished fourth on two of the biggest occasions of his career — at the 2022 World Championships and the Asian Games. The latter finish was particularly devastating. He had set an Asian record in qualifying and was leading comfortably when he shot a 7.6, leaving him agonisingly short of a podium finish.

Kusale's talent was undeniable. The son of a schoolteacher from the village of Kambalwadi near

Kolhapur, he was handed a rifle at 14 as part of *Kreeda Probodhini*, Maharashtra's sports promotion initiative.

Coaches soon recognised his potential, and his father believed in him too. A village schoolteacher of meagre means, he bought Kusale's first air rifle on loan with a high interest rate and continued to pay off the debt until four years ago.

Despite his family's trust, Kusale felt he wasn't living up to their expectations. In 2018, after failing to make the Indian squad for the Asian Games, he got his first tattoo with the words 'I promise' on his right

forearm. "I did that because I felt I wasn't justifying my talent. I believed in my goals and couldn't afford to be casual or lazy. I had to make that promise to myself," he says.

Kusale's coaches, especially his personal coach Deepali Deshpande, who he calls his second mother, continued to believe in him. Joydeep Karmakar, a fourth-place finisher at the 2012 Olympics and national team coach between 2021 and 2022, also saw his potential.

"He is the closest in temperament to Gagan Narang. In terms of aggressiveness, he is like a 20-tonne truck when he finds his momentum.